



Photograph: Arun Gandhi, Imaging Vijay Padayra

The Made-in-India Browser

In a tiny Madhya Pradesh village, a physically challenged Jagdeep Dangi has created a Hindi language browser

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All major ISPs, some NGOs, and the government, both state and central, talk of bringing the Internet to the masses. Here in *Digit*, we have showcased the efforts of all of them. We have shown you how people in the remotest of villages are getting tech-savvy, and how most of them use the Internet.

Why is the Internet so important? Why is it that even farmers from tiny villages have felt its touch? There are two primary reasons for it: information at your fingertips, and communication. It might be a great idea to wire up every square kilometre of our country and plug it into the Internet, but whether any good will come of it is a matter of debate.

What good is information to us if it's in Dutch, or German, or Swahili? English is just as foreign a language to the Indian masses as Swahili is to us. If you are reading this, you are a part of a tiny minority in India.

If there were any doubts as to the tech prowess of our villages, Jagdeep Dangi has silenced them. He hails from a tiny village called

Gram Bhunwara, near Ganj Basoda—a small town in Vidisha district of Madhya Pradesh. Against all odds, Dangi educated himself, and spent three years coding and nurturing his Hindi Internet browser.

"Why a browser?" we asked him. "The majority of PC users want to get on the Internet. The Internet is accessed through a Web browser, and so is vital to the masses," he says.

He adds, "Today, everything of importance is on the Internet—exam results, news, e-mail, etc. This browser will also be useful to many governments' rural IT education programs."

How He Did It

Like the nameless millions, Dangi hit upon a very real roadblock to his engineering career—English. While we take the language for granted (look around you to get an idea of how pervasive English is: if you wish to learn anything, you better know English), Dangi faced immense hurdles while trying to communicate in English while earning his degree.

The experience, far from scarring, made him determined to ensure that no one else needed to go through the language maze.